



Leadership Role for Strategic Planning

Daniel Cabrera

American Military University

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Professor Webber

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Abstract

Leader activity and tasks are important elements of the strategic process overall. For helping with implementation, understanding key elements, leaders can lead strategy through their actions or decisions. In order to better lead strategic change managers and leaders can engage in ten interconnected tasks to help encourage strategy or create wider discussions around organizational objectives. This writing takes a look at five of those ten leader task strategic behaviors; sponsoring the process, championing the process, using dialog to affect strategy, enforcing policy, and putting it all together.

Leadership Role for Strategic Planning

Leader tasks are interconnected with an organization's larger strategic plan. How a leader or manager behaves, and the decisions they make can influence the tone of an organization. Leaders are responsible for developing mission and vision, they seek to find new ways to maximize success and are not afraid to break from norms.

Manager behavior is more traditional; it should be organizationally focused and in line with established organizational protocols. Both leaders and managers help define their environments through their actions and decisions. Leaders can be sponsors and champions, affect strategy through dialog, and pull the elements of strategy together with their efforts. In order to better assess leader interconnected task behaviors five total leader actions are addressed here.

Sponsoring and Championing the Process

Top leaders can be sponsors for projects, or champions. Both sponsors and champions bring with them the ability to energize employees and investors. Champions are more in the grit of day-to-day operating, where sponsors advocate and increase their vested interests and help inform strategic decisions for organizations. Champions energize by creating a tone and setting an example for organizational ideals. A champion who elevates organizational goals above personal interests is often also transformative, changing environments and employees in their orbit. Both sponsors and champions are important figures in the strategic plan rollout. Sponsors develop interest and help guide through key "decision points." (Bryson, 2011, p. 361). Champions provide the example and inspire positive organizational-oriented behaviors in others.

Affecting Strategy through Dialog and Enforcing

Strategy can be affected through dialog. Communication is key for successful strategic implementation. In order to help guide strategy leaders should; understand the design and use of forums, seize opportunities during uncertain conditions, identify needs, lead and frame issues, offer compelling future visions, improve ideas, and articulate desires and consequences for undesired activities. (Bryson, 2011, p. 376). Leaders must seek to understand their employees, their stakeholders, key figures in the community, and themselves. Leaders or managers must know their limitations as well as their strengths to capitalize on their best individual assets or know where to delegate. By opening channels of dialog and collaborating with employees at all levels in the workplace on challenges effective challenge solutions can come about. Rules or expectations should be communicated also along with desired behavior and consequences for infractions.

Putting Together

Finally, leaders must bring together the different pieces of strategy and put them together to create a functioning plan. Pulling the plan together can benefit “organizations, collaborations, and [help] communities become places in which strategic thinking, acting, and learning simply become the way things are done.” (Bryson, 2011, p. 382). Collaboration is key and leaders must get other leaders, investors, employees, and community members on the same page. Coordinating the different components of strategy into an operational plan takes effort, and leaders must continually develop the plan and assess when certain pieces should be modified. Through behavior interconnected with organizational strategy leaders can influence their

followers via personal actions when their understanding of the strategic plan is well put together also.

Conclusion

Leader task behaviors are linked/interconnected to larger organizational goals. Leaders and managers both can be vehicles of organizational intentions and affect change through their actions. Sponsors and champions of process planning are leaders who act in ways that are consistent with organizational prerogatives, setting an example and energizing followers. Strategy can be influenced through dialog, and seeking ideas from others across all levels of organization can provide unique solutions – even under bemusing circumstances. Lastly, like organizational strategy, leaders must put together strategy at the individual level as well. Collaboration will be fostered by good leaders along with coordination across teams. The greater leaders understand themselves, and the organization's strategic vision, the greater their strategic influence will be.

References

Bryson, J. *Strategic Planning for Public and Nonprofit Organizations: A Guide to Strengthening and Sustaining Organizational Achievement*. USA: Jossey-Bass, 2011. Print. Pages 361, 376, and 382.